guns in the middle of the night, our patrol leader dropped his mobile phone and alerted the enemy. Half of the team got lost before the final firefight.

We can look back and laugh at the absurdity of it all, but it certainly got the 2013–14 Ashes tour off to a bad start. Poor planning was exacerbated by questionable selection decisions. Individually, several players were past their best. Collectively, we lacked the cohesion that defined the team that climbed to number one in the world.

Warning signs were ignored. I was as enthusiastic as anyone when we called up Boyd Rankin, a 6ft 8in fast bowler who had transferred allegiances from Ireland, at the age of twenty-nine, after a nine-year, 82-cap career for his home country. A strapping farmer's son, he had a distinctive action. Though evidently prone to bouts of cramp, he caused batsmen a different set of problems.

Initially selected for the one-day series after the Oval, he was unplayable in practice. Ashley Giles, who had come into the England set-up, had coached him for Warwickshire. We wanted to let him loose in the first match at Southampton, but he was forced to withdraw the night before with a back spasm.

By the time he made his Test debut at Sydney, four months later, the Ashes tour had collapsed. It was his first match for five weeks. He admitted to being consumed by nerves, reported a back spasm on the first morning, and was twice forced to limp off with cramp. His only Test wicket for England, when he incited Peter Siddle into a top-edged pull, came from his last delivery.

Australia went into the series on their worst winless run since 1986. They were blighted by injuries that ruled out emerging quickies Mitchell Starc, James Pattinson and Pat Cummins. Mitchell Johnson was deemed to be chronically wayward, a caricature gunslinger. We were unbeaten in thirteen Tests and forbidding favourites.

I'm not going to shy away from the depth of our problems, but credit where it is due. Johnson's speed, hostility and accuracy exposed weaknesses in our technique and temperament. I spoke to him after the series, when he admitted to being initially nervous about further ridicule. To come back in that manner showed the psychological strength of a champion.

Nathan Lyon, Ryan Harris and Peter Siddle bowled at their best. Michael Clarke scored early hundreds and proved to be a very impressive, tactically